

Lesson 3 - The Six Schools of Indian Philosophy - Overview

Learning objectives:

- 1] Understand the six major schools of Indian philosophy.
- 2] Recognize key concepts and philosophers of each school.
- 3] Appreciate the contemporary relevance of Indian philosophical thought.
- 4] Understand key concepts of Indian orthodox philosophies.
- 5] Explore Charvaka, Buddhism and Jainism. Beliefs and influence.
- 6] Identify philosophical principles, materialism, and non-self-multiple truths.

Topic 1 - Understanding philosophy in the Indian context.

Let us start with the concept of philosophy. The word philosophy combines two words, namely philos, which means love and sophia means wisdom. So philosophy means love for wisdom or love of knowledge. It is a quest for understanding the fundamental truths about the world around us and also about ourselves. In this world, people are pursuing so many questions what is the real nature of a man and the nature of this world? So philosophy deals with these issues as extensively as possible. The Sanskrit term for philosophy is darshana, that is, the vision of truth. The word darshana is derived from the root dhrusha, which means to see. And so darshana implies a way to realize or to see or visualize the world through philosophy. All philosophical systems strive hard to find out the answer about the universe. Indian philosophical systems are mainly divided into two astika and nastika. Astika philosophical systems believe in the Vedas. They accept the authority of the Vedas, or in other words, they accept the Veda, pramana, and Nastika philosophical systems. They do not believe in the Vedic tradition. They question or challenge the authority of Vedic tradition. The classification of astika and nastika has nothing to do with thinking and non-believing in God. Let's start by understanding what we mean by philosophy. The term comes from the Greek word philos, meaning love, and sophia, meaning wisdom. So philosophy is essentially the love of wisdom, but it goes beyond that. It is a pursuit, a quest for understanding the fundamental truths about ourselves, the world around us, and our place in it. It involves asking questions, challenging assumptions, and exploring complex ideas. Philosophy plays a significant role in shaping Indian culture and thinking. It is interwoven into our mythology, literature, art, and everyday life. Indian philosophy is not just about abstract thought.

It also offers guidance on ethics, duty, dharma, and the path to spiritual liberation. Moksha, for instance. The lessons from the Bhagavad Gita or the Upanishads are reflected in the values and moral frameworks of many Indian households even today. While Western and Indian philosophy both seek to unravel the truths of existence, their approach differs. Western philosophy often uses a method of systematic logical inquiry, focusing on areas like science, ethics, politics, and aesthetics. Indian philosophy, on the other hand, is more holistic. It intertwines spiritual, ethical, and metaphysical questions with an emphasis on personal spiritual realization. It's like comparing a microscope to a kaleidoscope but showing us truths, from different perspectives. Now let's delve into the concept of darshan. In Sanskrit, darshan means to see, implying a viewpoint or a way of seeing the world. Each darshan offers a unique perspective on fundamental questions of life and existence. They are not merely theoretical frameworks but are intended as practical guides to lead us toward self-realization and enlightenment. Now let us have a look at the concept of shaddarshanas or the major six philosophical systems. These six schools or orthodox schools of Indian philosophy are Nyaya philosophy or The Nyaya Darshana Vaisheshika philosophy or Vaisheshika Darshana Samkhya philosophy or Samkhya Darshana yoga philosophy or yoga darshana, Purvami Mīmāṃsā, and Uttara mimamsa. To understand each philosophical system, one must know these four concepts which are so important in any philosophical system. These four terms are pramāṇa which means a knower, pramāya which means knowable pramāṇa, the process of knowing and pramiti, the resultant knowledge. With the help of these four, one can acquire the knowledge of the philosophical system. Now, what are Shaddarshans? Shad means six and darshans are the philosophies we just discussed. So Shaddarshans refers to the six main orthodox schools of Indian philosophy, Nyai, Vaisheshik, Samkhya, yoga, Mimamsa, and Vedant. Each school has its unique focus ranging from logic and analysis to metaphysics and spirituality, and collectively they form the foundation of Indian philosophical thought. Lastly, why are these Shaddarshans important to us today? Studying these philosophies doesn't just provide us with a greater understanding of India's rich cultural heritage, it also gives us novel perspectives to reflect on modern challenges. For instance, Nyaya's emphasis on logical reasoning can aid in critical thinking, while yoga's focus on mind-body wellness finds resonance in modern mental health conversations. Hence, these age-old philosophies still hold profound relevance in our contemporary world.

Topic 2 - The Nyaya philosophy: introduction and key concepts

Among these six philosophical systems, the first and foremost school is The Nyaya school. The Nyaya school is one of the schools of Indian philosophy and was founded by Akshapada Gautama. The basic text of The Nyaya school of philosophy is The Nyaya Sutra of Gautama. Later on, The Nyaya Sutra of Gautama was explained or commented on by Vatsyayana, namely The The Nyaya Bhashya and afterward The The Nyaya Vartika by Udyotakara. and afterward The The Nyaya Vartika by Udyotakara. Then what is the meaning of the term The Nyaya? Then what is the meaning of the term The Nyaya? The Nyaya means simply logic. The Nyaya means simply logic. The other name for this The Nyaya system is the other name for The Nyaya system is Anvikshiki, which means the science of inquiry. Anvikshiki, which means the science of inquiry. What is the use of this system? What is the use of this system? The The Nyaya system of philosophy is providing The Nyaya system of philosophy is providing a tool or methodology for argumentation a tool or methodology for argumentation which is required in everyday life. Which is required in everyday life. What is the use of The Nyaya system, What is the use of this The Nyaya system, whether it is relevant today or not? Whether it is relevant today or not. According to The Nyaya philosophy, the knowledge According to The Nyaya philosophy, knowledge is divided into four divisions. is divided into four divisions. The Nyaya philosophy accepts four types of pramanads, namely, pratyaksha means perception, anumana pramanads, namely, pratyaksha means perception, anumana means inference, upamana, which is comparison, which means inference, upamana, that is comparison, and shabda that is verbal testimony. and shabda which is verbal testimony. The Nyaya philosophy is one of the important philosophical systems, throws The The Nyaya philosophy is one of the important philosophical systems, throws light on all other branches of learning, and it provides light on all other branches of learning, and it provides a rational basis for all actions and the support of a rational basis for all actions and the support of all the laws, as it is rightly stated. all the laws, as it is rightly stated. About The The Nyaya philosophy as Pradipaha Sarva Vidyanam About The The Nyaya philosophy as Pradipaha Sarva Vidyanam, Upayaha Sarva Karmanam Ashrayah Sarva dharamanam Shashvadanvikshiki Mata. let's begin our journey into the world of Nyai, one of the oldest philosophical of Nyai, one of the oldest philosophical systems from India. Systems from India. Founded by sage Akshapad Gautam nyai Founded by sage Akshapad Gautam, nyai means logic or rules of debate. Means logic or rules of debate. In Sanskrit, this philosophy is a guiding light, this philosophy is a guiding light, helping us to discern the complex phenomena around helping us to discern the complex phenomena around us by applying

structured thought and logical reasoning. Us by applying structured thought and logical reasoning. It's like playing chess with the universe, examining it's like playing chess with the universe, examining each move carefully before taking the next step. Each move carefully before taking the next step. Anvikshiki, or the science of logic, is Anvikshiki, or the science of logic, is at the heart of Nyai philosophy. At the heart of Nyai philosophy. It encourages us to be thorough investigators, much It encourages us to be thorough investigators, much like a detective unraveling the mysteries of existence. Like a detective unraveling the mysteries of existence. For instance, when scientists pursue a hypothesis in For instance when scientists pursue a hypothesis in modern research, they meticulously analyse data and draw modern research, they meticulously analyse data and conclusions, which mirrors the investigative process advocated by conclusions, mirror investigative process advocated by Anvikshiki thousands of years ago. Anvikshiki thousands of years ago. Nya's approach to knowledge and Nya's approach to knowledge and truth is truly fascinating. truth is truly fascinating. It asserts that we can attain valid knowledge, It asserts that we can attain valid knowledge, or prama, through careful analysis and inference. or prama, through careful analysis and inference. Let's compare it to baking a cake. Let's compare it to baking a cake. You have a recipe, You have a recipe, the hypothesis, and ingredients, the data. Hypothesis and ingredients, the data. By following the recipe and analysing By following the recipe and analysing the result, you validate the recipe's correctness similarly, result, you validate the recipe's correctness similarly, The The Nyaya's epistemology guides us in our quest The Nyaya's epistemology guides us in our quest for the sweet taste of truth. For the sweet taste of truth. Now imagine you're building a bridge Now imagine you're building a bridge from the unknown to the known. From the unknown to the known. How do you know it's safe to cross? How do you know it's safe to cross? Nya gives us four supports, or Nya gives us four supports, or pramans direct perception, pratyaksh inference, anumana pramans direct perception, pratyaksh inference, anumana comparison, upaman and verbal testimony shabdha. comparison, upaman, and verbal testimony shabdha. They ensure that the bridge to knowledge is sturdy and reliable. Knowledge is sturdy and reliable. For example, in a courtroom, evidence, witness testimony logical reasoning witness testimony, and logical reasoning are all used to reflect these four pramans. All are used to reflect these four pramans. Our journey would be incomplete without Our journey would be incomplete without recognizing the philosophers who shaped Nyai. Recognizing the philosophers who shaped Nyai. Akshapad Gautam, the founder, Akshapad Gautam, the founder, laid the philosophical foundation. Laid the philosophical foundation. His student Vatsyan further developed it. His student

Vatsyana further developed it. Centuries later, thinkers like Udayana further refined the system. They are like the lighthouse keepers, guiding us through the turbulent seas of ignorance towards the shore of knowledge. The influence of Nyaya on Indian thought is profound, from debates in ancient royal courts to the principles underpinning India's modern judicial system. Nyaya's legacy permeates various aspects of Indian society. Additionally, it provided the groundwork for scientific thinking as its rigorous analysis methods are aligned closely with the scientific process. So every time we use logic or analysis in our lives, we are in a way drawing from Nyaya's rich wisdom.

Topic 3 – Vaisheshika Philosophy: Introduction and Key Concepts

After the Nyaya philosophy let us have a look at the Vaisheshika philosophy. Vaisheshika philosophy one of the schools of Indian philosophy is known as the school of atomism. The name itself suggests that everything could be broken down into small indestructible particles. They are called *anu* or atoms. Vaisheshika philosophy was expounded by sage Kanada and later philosopher Prashastapada developed this philosophical system. The term vaisheshika is derived from the term *vishesha*, which means distinction or distinctive feature. Vaisheshika philosophy classifies all objects into seven categories, namely, *dravya* means substance, *guna* means quality *karma* means action or activity *samanya* means universal *vishesha* means particular *samavaya* means permanent relationship *abhava* means nonexistence. These are seven categories discussed by Vaisheshika philosophy. One must note here that Kanada accepts only six categories and *abhava* is a later addition to this philosophical system. Vaisheshika, one of the six classical schools of Indian philosophy, was founded by the sage Kanada. It is often called the school of atomism as it postulates that all objects in the physical universe are reducible to a finite number of atoms. It focuses on understanding reality in a very rational and analytical way, almost similar to how a modern scientist would approach natural phenomena. But unlike modern physics, Vaisheshika links its philosophical ontology to a moral one, subtly interweaving ethics into its material worldview. The categories of existence in Vaisheshika, the universe is composed of *padarthas* or

categories of existence. There are seven such categories, including substance, quality, activity, generality, particularity inherits, and nonexistence. These categories provide a comprehensive framework for describing reality. For example, the substance dravya can be anything from fire, and water to air, much like we would categorize elements in modern science. Proving how Vaisheshik integrated metaphysics and physics, Vaisheshik's school proposed one of the earliest forms of atomic theory. Kanada, the school's founder, suggested that everything could be broken down into tiny, indestructible particles called anu, or atoms. This idea parallels modern scientific theories about matter's atomic nature. Although the vaishic atoms are thought to possess a consciousness and other metaphysical attributes distinguishing them from the purely physical atoms of contemporary science. While Kanada is the foundational figure in Vaisheshik, other philosophers like Prashastapad, Udayan, and Sridhar further developed the system. They made significant contributions to the refinement and elaboration of the concepts initially posited by Kanada, much like successive scientists, building upon the theories of their predecessors, and enriching our understanding of the universe over time. The Vaisheshik School merged with the Nyai School, resulting in a synthesized philosophy that combined Nya's emphasis on logic and analysis with Vaisheshik's detailed metaphysical categories. This is akin to different academic disciplines merging today, such as biochemistry, which combines biology and chemistry, resulting in a richer understanding of life. The Vaisheshik School, with its atomic theory and categorization of existence, significantly influenced Indian philosophical and scientific thought. It laid the groundwork for systematic thought reminiscent of modern scientific taxonomies. Furthermore, integrating physical and moral ontology, reminds us that science and ethics need not be compartmentalized, but can be unified in a holistic worldview.

Topic 4 - Samkhya Philosophy: Introduction and key concepts

The third school of the philosophical system is Samkhya philosophy. Samkhya is one of the oldest philosophical pools in India. Kapilamuni is often referred to as the founder of this philosophical system. The main contribution of this philosophical system is Samkhya accepts 25 principles. Some of them are Prakruti, Mahat, Buddhi, Ahankara, etc. Samkhya's philosophy focuses on the evolution of the universe. It is composed of Purusha and Prakriti. The other name for Prakruti is Pradhana where Purusha remains constant, unchanging, and all the changes occur in the prakruti. But at the same time, the presence of Purusha is necessary. Purusha is neither kartha, which means doer of action nor bhokta, which is experiencer. Purusha is Shuddha, Chaitanya, and Prakruti is Jada in Samkhya philosophy. In Samkhya philosophy, liberation or moksha is the realization of the distinction between Prakruti and

Purusha. The important contribution of Samkhya philosophy is Satkarya Vada in the process of evolution. The important theory of causation, that is, Satkarya vada, is peculiar to this Samkhya philosophical system. Then what is the meaning of the word Satkaryavada? What is the meaning of the term Satkaryavada? Satkaryavada. This theory believes that the effect is in the cause itself. For example, if we wish to prepare a cloth, then thread is required and not mud. In short, in Satkarya vada, karya is always in the calls. The Samkhya karika of Ishvarakrishna is the earliest available manual of this system which is so important to understand. Samkhya philosophical system Samkhya, one of the oldest philosophical schools of India, offers a unique perspective on the world. Imagine two distinct threads, one black, and one white, entwined to create the fabric of reality. In a similar vein, Samkhya presents a dualistic framework where the universe is composed of two primary realities, Prakriti, the material aspect, and Purush, the consciousness. It's like comparing it to an unscripted play where Prakriti is the stage and props, while Purush is the silent spectator. To delve deeper into this dualism, consider Prakriti and Purush as the yin and yang of Indian philosophy. Prakriti, much like the force of nature, is dynamic, creative, and responsible for everything tangible. On the other hand, Purush is pure consciousness, passive, unchanging, and untainted. Like a serene lake reflecting the world without being affected by it. Samkhya views the evolution of the universe as an intricate dance between Prakriti and Purush. Picture a dormant seed, Prakriti, germinating into a vibrant tree under the warmth of the sun. Purush. Just as the seed transforms into various forms, roots, trunk, branches, leaves, flowers, and fruits, Prakriti, too, catalysed by Purush's proximity, evolves into the multifarious world we experience. When it comes to the stalwarts of Samkhya, the sage Kapil is often revered as the founder. Imagine him as an insightful gardener, planting seeds of knowledge that grew into the majestic tree of Samkhya philosophy, its branches providing intellectual shelter for generations to come. In Samkhya, liberation, or moksha, is the realization of the distinction between Prakriti and Purush. Imagine you're watching a gripping movie and suddenly recognize that you're merely a spectator, not a participant. Similarly, liberation comes from recognizing oneself as Purush, the detached observer separate from Prakriti's constant flux. The influence of Samkhya is far-reaching, from its impact on yoga and Ayurveda to even contemporary psychology. Its insights into the human mind and its nature-based approach to understanding reality echo in today's ecological awareness and sustainable living movements. As modern India strides towards technological and mental challenges, Samkhya's principles continue to provide meaningful insights.

Topic 5 - Yoga philosophy: introduction and key concepts

Let us see the fourth philosophical system of this tradition, namely Yoga. Yoga is the correct pronunciation and not yoga. Yoga is one of the important systems of Indian philosophy. Patanjali's Yoga Sutra is considered the foundational scripture of yoga philosophy. Vyasa's commentary on Yoga Sutra which is known as Vyasabhashya is the most authoritative work in this system. Yoga also accepts 25 principles of Samkhya but adds the 26th principle, that is God to them. And so yoga is known as Seshwara Samkhya while Samkhya is Nirishvara Samkhya. Yoga philosophy agrees with Samkhya's philosophy. According to them, bondage is due to the non-discrimination that is viveka between Purusha and Prakruti and liberation is due to discrimination that is viveka between them. Yoga also regards knowledge that is jnana. Concentration is ekagrata and action that is kriya is the means of liberation. The term yoga is derived from the verbal root yuj means to fix upon the mind, to think, or to meditate upon. Yoga is not only meant for physical exercise but to achieve balance and harmony in the mind and body. It gives us direct experience or self-realization. The journey to self-realization is outlined as the Ashtanga yoga or the eightfold path which has been discussed by Patanjali in his Patanjala Yoga Sutra. These eight steps are yama means the practice of restraints and niyama observances. Asana means bodily posture, pranayama means breath control, and pratyahara means withdrawal of the sense organs. Dharana means the fixation of attention, dhyana means meditation, and samadhi, is ecstasy. In Samadhi, there are two types of samadhis discussed by Patanjali. One is Nirvikalpa samadhi and other one is Savikalpa samadhi. Yoga philosophy has greatly influenced Indian as well as global thought. It is an integral part of cultural practices and also everyday life. Yoga, derived from the Sanskrit verb yuj, meaning to join or unite, is much more than the physical exercises popularized worldwide. Yoga is an ancient Indian philosophical system that aims to unite the individual self with the universal consciousness. It's a profound path that enables self-discovery, self-mastery, and ultimate realization. Its core teachings can provide invaluable insights into the complex dynamics of the human mind and body, helping to achieve balance and harmony in life. In the yoga philosophy, the journey of self-realization is outlined as the Astanga yoga and the Eightfold path as proposed by the sage Patanjali. These eight steps yam or moral codes niyam, self-purification and study asan posture, pranayam, breath control, pratyahar, withdrawal of the senses, dharana concentration, dhyana meditation and samadhi state of super consciousness offer a systematic pathway to attain physical, ethical, emotional and psychospiritual health. Yoga asserts a deep interconnection between the mind and body, a concept that has been progressively recognized in modern healthcare. It's like

tuning a musical instrument. When the body and mind are in harmony, optimal health is achieved. Yoga practices such as asanas and meditation foster this harmony, enhancing mental clarity and physical well-being. In contemporary India, yoga is widely incorporated into daily routines, acknowledging its role in stress management and holistic health. Patanjali, often called the father of yoga, is a significant figure who codified the knowledge of yoga in the yoga sutras. This text is considered the foundational scripture of yoga philosophy, delineating the path towards self-realization. Patanjali's wisdom continues to guide yoga practitioners worldwide. Today, the influence of yoga on health and wellness is globally acknowledged. Modern wellness practices frequently incorporate yoga techniques for their benefits in enhancing physical fitness, reducing stress, and promoting mental peace. For instance, corporations in India often offer yoga sessions to their employees, recognizing their effectiveness in boosting productivity and maintaining mental health. Yoga philosophy has greatly influenced both Indian and global thought. In India, yoga is integral to cultural practices and everyday life. Globally, yoga's popularity has surged, celebrated even by the United Nations with the International Day of Yoga. Yoga's emphasis on holistic health, mind-body harmony, and mindful living resonates with modern society's need to balance rapid technological advancement with inner well-being.

Topic 6 - Mimamsa philosophy: introduction and key concepts

The next philosophical system is Purva Mimamsa, or it is also known as only Mimamsa or Vakyaartha shastra, the science of sentence interpretation. The term Mimamsa is derived from the root mana. Meaning is to worship, and another meaning is to think. It is stated as mana pujayam and mana vichari. So Mimamsa means pujita vicharu. Mimamsa deals with the ritual part of the Veda which means it deals with karmakanda. In other words, Mimamsa is concerned with the prior part of the Veda. Jaimini was the founder of this system, and the first available work on Mimamsa is Jaimini's Mimamsa sutra. In fact, Jaimini has systematized the Mimamsa philosophy. Jaimini's contribution to this philosophical system is enormous. Shabaraswami wrote a bhashya means commentary on the Mimamsa sutra, which is known as shabarabhashya. Mimamsa emphasizes that every single sentence in the Veda is meaningful. So according to Mimamsa, the whole Veda is meaningful. There are two basic concepts or important concepts in Mimamsa. Karma, which means action, and dharma, that is, duty, are the two sides of the same coin. In other words, when one performs one's duty very well, ultimately the other's right is protected. So in ancient India, we come across the duty-based society. As stated earlier, Mimamsa is the science of sentence interpretation. Its interpretative methods have been applied to

all knowledge domains such as legal texts, linguistics, literary criticism, etc. Mimamsa, one of the profound Indian philosophical systems, heavily emphasizes ritualistic knowledge and practice. Imagine it as a meticulous baker who is less concerned about why a cake rises and more focused on executing the precise steps to ensure the cake comes out perfectly every time. In this sense, Mimamsa may not ask existential questions about the universe but prioritizes the how-to process, centering around the rituals described in the Vedas. Picture the Vedas as a dense forest and Mimamsa as a mapmaker plotting the paths and meanings throughout the forest. Mimamsa thrives on decoding Vedic texts, operating on the principle that every single word, phrase, and ritual in the Vedas has a purpose. This is akin to a grammarian's dedication to understanding language where even punctuation has significance. Mimamsa sees rituals as a sort of cosmic technology, aligning humans with the cosmic order, or *rutha*, somewhat like gears in a watch, synchronizing to tell the correct time. In philosophy, karma, and dharma interplay as action and moral duty acting as two sides of the same coin. Just as the law of gravity governs the physical world, Mimamsa believes the moral law of karma governs the moral realm. Jaimini, the founder of Mimamsa, can be compared to a master architect. His sutras provide the blueprint for structuring complex rituals and ethical codes. His systematic analysis of Vedic rituals and their purpose forms the very foundation of Mimamsa, showing the way for later philosophers to build upon it. Just as successive generations of builders contribute to a growing city. Much as an advocate interprets the law to argue a case, Mimamsa's rigorous interpretative methods have been applied to legal texts shaping Indian jurisprudence. Its approach to understanding dharma. The moral law can be seen as an early legal philosophy that laid the groundwork for legal principles in ancient India, just as *Carta* did in the West. The influence of Mimamsa extends beyond philosophy and permits various aspects of Indian culture. It's akin to the roots of a tree, not always visible but providing the vital foundation and nutrients for the tree to grow. Its detailed analysis of Vedic rituals influences religious practices, and its interpretative methods have impacted not just law but also grammar, linguistics, and even scriptural commentary. In India.

Topic 7 - Vedanta philosophy: introduction

Last but not least is Uttara Mimamsa or Vedanta which is one of the famous systems of Indian philosophy concerned with the posterior part of the Veda, that is *dna*. *Kanda Dhnana* was the main focus of this philosophical system. In the true sense of the term Vedanta. It is the end part of the Veda which is known as Upanishads. The important foundation of Vedanta is Vedanta sutras or Shariraka Sutras of Bada Rayana. It is also known as Brahma Sutras as its main subject matter is Brahma or Brahman.

Shankaracharya was the greatest philosopher among the thinkers in the Indian intellectual tradition. His exposition is known as Advaita Vedanta as we are all aware. His philosophy may be summarized by this quote as *Brahma Satyam, Jagan, Mithya, Jivo, Brahmaiva, Naparaha* Vedanta philosophy exploring most profound questions such as who am I? What is the nature of this universe where we come from? So on and so forth. The central concept of Vedanta philosophy is the concept of Brahman. Vedanta philosophy mainly deals with these concepts, namely Jiva, Jagat, Brahman, and Atman. There are three main schools of Vedanta which are famously known as Shankaracharya Advaita Vedanta, Madhva chariots, Dwaita Vedanta, and Ramanuja chariots Visishta Dwaita there are three main schools of Vedanta. The first one is Shankaracharya Advaita Vedanta second one is Madhvacharyas, Dwaita Vedanta and the third one is Ramanujacharya's Vishishta Daita Vedanta. The important point is they all have commented on the Brahma Sutras. These three are the main pillars of the Vedanta philosophical system, each contributing a unique interpretation of the same Upanishadik sentences. Vedanta philosophy or Vedanta's teachings have travelled far beyond the borders and are not limited to India alone. So let us dive into this ocean of wisdom and explore the fascinating world of Indian philosophy which is relevant today. Vedanta, also known as Uttara Mimamsa, is one of the six orthodox schools of Indian philosophy. The term Vedanta translates to the end of the Vedas as it primarily draws its teachings from the concluding portions of the Vedas known as the Upanishads. Like reading the last chapter of a book, Vedanta seeks to conclude our understanding of life and reality, exploring some of the most profound metaphysical questions who are we? What is the nature of the universe? What is our place in it? In a sense, Vedant is like the grand finale of a spectacular fireworks display, summarizing and illuminating the key ideas that pervade the earlier philosophical systems. At the heart of Vedanta philosophy lies the concept of Brahman. Derived from the Upanishads, Brahman is the absolute, all-encompassing reality, somewhat akin to the concept of cosmic energy or the universe itself. However, Brahman is more than just a grand physical entity. It is the spiritual essence that permeates everything in existence. To comprehend this, think of the Ocean. Each wave is distinct, yet it's made up of the same water as the entire ocean. Similarly, everything in the universe is a manifestation of Brahman. Vedant introduces the idea of Atman, our true self or individual soul, it posits that Atman and Brahman are the same. This is a radical idea, suggesting that we are not just part of the universe, but in essence, we are the universe. It's like realizing that the wave is not separate from the ocean but a part of it. Self-realization, then, is the understanding of this profound truth of our ultimate identity with Brahman, leading to a state of eternal bliss and liberation. Vedant,

though unified in its focus on Brahman and Atman, presents different viewpoints through its three main schools, Advait, Dwait, and Vishishta. Dwait, Advait, propagated by Adi Shankar, espouses non-duality, stating, there's no difference between Atman and Brahman. Imagine it as a drop of water merging into the ocean, losing its separate identity. On the other hand, Dwaita, established by Madhava, asserts a clear distinction between individual souls and the ultimate reality spearheaded by Ramanuja, finds a middle ground, proposing that the soul, while distinct, exists within the realm of the divine, much like threads woven into a fabric. Adi Shankar, Ramanuja and Madhwa are the main pillars of Vedant, each contributing a unique interpretation. Shankar, akin to a master chef, stirred the pot of philosophical thought with his Advait doctrine, advocating the fundamental oneness of all existence. Ramanuja is like an expert gardener, nurturing the idea of qualified non-duality, asserting that the soul and universe are aspects of the divine, yet maintaining their distinct identities. Madhava, similar to a sharp mathematician, drew clear lines with his dwait philosophy, highlighting the separation between the individual soul and the ultimate reality. Vedanta philosophy has a profound impact on Indian thought and culture. It has shaped the way people perceive the world and themselves. The teachings of Vedant have inspired spiritual seekers, philosophers, and artists throughout the ages. Its message of unity, self-realization, and the pursuit of truth has influenced various aspects of Indian society, including literature, art, music, and daily life. Vedant's teachings are not limited to India alone. They have travelled far beyond their borders, touching the hearts and minds of people worldwide. The wisdom of Vedant has found resonance in the works of renowned thinkers, scientists, and spiritual leaders, enriching the global philosophical and spiritual landscape. Vedant is not just a subject to be studied it is a path to be lived. So let us dive into this ocean of wisdom together and explore the fascinating world of Vedant. Philosophy.

Topic 8 - Vedant philosophy: Detailed study

Have you ever watched a magic show and wondered how the tricks work? They seem real, but you know that they aren't. This is somewhat similar to the concept of Maya. In Vedanta, Maya refers to the illusionary nature of the world, which appears to be real, but according to Vedanta, is not the ultimate reality. Just like a rope mistaken for a snake in dim light, the world is perceived due to ignorance of its real nature. The true understanding is that the world is not separate from Brahman—the supreme reality. Moksha or liberation in Vedant, is the realization of one's true nature as Brahman imagine it like waking up from a dream. In a dream, you might be someone else in a different place, but upon waking you realize your true state. Similarly,

Vedanta says, our current state is like a dream due to ignorance, and moksha is waking up to the ultimate reality of oneness. With Brahman, consider a traffic system. To have smooth flow and order, we need certain rules and regulations. Similarly, in the path to self-realization, the ethics of dharma plays a crucial role. Ethical living, according to Vedant, means leading a life of truth, non-violence, self-control, and compassion. It's the foundation for attaining the spiritual goal as it brings inner peace and harmony, making it conducive to spiritual realization. Vedant's influence on Indian spirituality can be compared to the base of a skyscraper. It's not always visible, but it's the foundation that holds the structure. Vedant's teachings form the basis of various spiritual practices like meditation, yoga, and mindfulness. These practices are designed to help us transcend our egoistic self and experience our true nature, which is none other than Brahman. Just as modern science speaks about the interconnectedness of the universe, Vedant propounds the principle of unity, stating that all existence is one. The concept of Brahman aligns with the scientific view of a unified field of consciousness, an all-pervading entity. Moreover, the mind-body dualism in Vedant can be correlated with the neuroscience's mind-brain dichotomy. Vedant's holistic view offers interesting parallels with modern scientific theories. The teachings of Vedant have spread far and wide. Just like Indian spices have found a place in global cuisine, the concepts of Atman, Brahman, and Maya have influenced the works of many Western philosophers and scientists. In contemporary times, mindfulness, a practice rooted in Vedanta, has gained global popularity for managing stress and promoting mental wellness. Thus, Vedanta continues to contribute to philosophical and spiritual thought worldwide.

Topic 9 - Indian Philosophies: Heterodox schools of Indian philosophy

Indian philosophical systems are divided into two main branches, Astika and Nastika. Astika philosophical systems, or orthodox philosophical systems, believe in the Vedic tradition. They accept the Vedas, or they accept the authority of Veda Pramanya. Nastika philosophical systems do not believe in the Vedic tradition. Rather, they question or challenge the authority of Vedic tradition. The classification of astika and nastika, or orthodox and heterodox, has nothing to do with believing and nonbelieving in God. To understand a particular philosophical system or thought, one must discover the worldviews of the philosopher. Charvaka is often seen as the embodiment of scepticism within the grand tapestry of Indian philosophies rooted in staunch materialism and atheism, Charvaka was a radical departure from the metaphysical beliefs of its contemporaries. It posited that life should be lived with the primary goal of seeking pleasure and avoiding pain, similar to the heronistic philosophies you may have heard of from the Western world. It's like a friend who

always encourages you to enjoy the here and now rather than worrying about an unseen future or afterlife. Charvak is one of the heterodox philosophical systems. They do not believe in the Vedic tradition. They question or challenge the authority of the Vedas. Charvak etymologically means charvak, sweet tongue. They have sweet words. They are also known as the lokayat system. It accepts only the reality of the material world and criticises the concepts of karma and rebirth. Since this is the only life, their notion is Runam krutva, ghrutam pibet. One has to enjoy this life and seek the utmost pleasure. They accept the only means of knowledge is pratyaksha, that is, perception, and deny the validity of means of knowledge, such as aluman and shabda. They do not believe in all the five elements, that is, panchamahabhuta of the material world. They deny the existence of Akash because it cannot be perceived. Think of Buddhism as a compassionate doctor. It diagnoses life's primary ailment, suffering. Dukkha identifies its cause like a doctor pinpoints the cause of a disease and then prescribes a cure in the form of the Eightfold Path. It's a holistic approach to address the existential crisis inherent in human life. Buddhism introduces us to the concept of Anantha, or anon self-like, telling us that what we see in the mirror isn't our real self. It speaks of karma, not as a system of reward and punishment, but as a simple law of cause and effect. Its ultimate goal, nirvana, is not a place but a state of being, like reaching a peaceful summit after a strenuous mountain trek. The multiple streams of Buddhism, Theravad, Mahayan, and Vajrayana, are like different routes to climb the same mountain today. Their impact extends beyond religious and philosophical realms, influencing modern psychology, mindfulness practices, and even approaches to stress management. Jain philosophy offers a unique perspective on reality. It teaches Anikantavad the idea that truth has multiple facets, like a prism splitting light into different colors. Siyadvad its principle of conditional viewpoints reminds us that our perspective is just one amongst many. It's like watching a football match from different camera angles. Each view gives you a different aspect of the same event. Jainism views karma not just as a metaphysical concept, but as a physical substance that affects the soul. Imagine having sticky notes attached to you for every action you perform. Its notion of liberation, moksha, involves freeing the soul from this karmic accumulation through strict practices of nonviolence, ahimsa, and asceticism. The gen ethical system marked by nonviolence, truthfulness, and nonattachment may seem rigorous, but it holds valuable lessons for the modern world. It's like a strict coach training us for a healthier, more considerate life, influencing modern discourses on environmental ethics, vegetarianism, and animal rights.

Learning outcomes:

- 1] Understand six major schools of Indian philosophy.
- 2] Recognize key concepts of each philosophical system.
- 3] Appreciate India's contribution to global philosophy and culture.
- 4] Inspire further exploration and interdisciplinary study.